

his mojo. A semifinal finish at the French Open brought him some much-needed breathing room. Then, at the All England Championships, Lakshya looked like he had rediscovered some of the touch that saw him make the 2022 finals in Birmingham, with a semifinal finish this time.

He beat World No. 4 and the form player of the season, Anders Antonsen, in the second round and former All-England champion Lee Zii Jia in the quarterfinals. At times, Lakshya was teetering on the edge in both matches; he shrugged off a 6-12 deficit in the decider against Antonsen and was soundly beaten 13-21 in the opening game of his quarterfinals against Jia.

Then, in the semifinals, he bounced back from a game down to

force a decider and even briefly held the edge before falling short against Indonesia's Jonatan Christie, who would go on to win the title.

The result leapfrogged Lakshya five places to 13 in the latest world ranking and assured that he would be in Paris in four months. But more significantly, Lakshya is not just scraping his way through anymore. Having found himself in a rich vein of form, he now has a significant tailwind behind him to take him to the French capital.

This outcome again places Lakshya's name in the discussion of India's top hopes for Paris. While he didn't start the week among the favourites, Lakshya proved his mettle in men's singles as other Indian

players faltered: H.S. Prannoy lost to Su Li Yang, P.V. Sindhu to An Se Young, and Chirag Shetty with Satwiksairaj Rankireddy in men's doubles to Bagas Maulana and Muhammad Shohibul Fikri. During an interview with Sportstar at the India Open, Lakshya's coach, Vimal Kumar, highlighted that the issue lies more in his mindset than his physical ability.

"He is injury-free, and he's training well, but of course, if you look at the last 4-5 months, he's been struggling at events," Kumar had said. "At the moment, he is low on confidence, and he's not playing the right game. That variation, he's not bringing in. He's trying to hit through in these sorts of (slow) conditions. He has to



WINNERS

Men's Singles: Jonatan Christie (Indonesia)

Women's Singles: An Seyoung (Korea)

Men's Doubles: Fajar Alfian/Muhammad Rian Ardianto (Indonesia)

Women's Doubles: Baek Ha-na/Lee So-hee (Korea)

Mixed Doubles: Zheng Siwei/Huang Yaqiong (China)

WHERE INDIANS FINISHED

Men's Singles: Lakshya Sen (Semifinals), HS Prannoy (1st round), Kidambi Srikanth (1st round), Priyanshu Rajawat (1st round)

Women's Singles: P V Sindhu (2nd round), Aakarshi Kashyap (1st round)

Men's Doubles: Satwiksairaj Rankireddy/Chirag Shetty (2nd round)

Women's Doubles: Ashwini Ponnappa/Tanisha Crasto (2nd round), Treesa Jolly/Gayatri Gopichand (1st round), Rutaparna Panda/Swetaparna Panda (1st round)



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